

King Charles Meets a Cricket Team That Can't Play for Its Own Country

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Imagine loving a sport so much, but your country's leaders say you can't play just because you're a girl. That's what happened to the Afghan women's cricket team. The **Taliban**, who rule Afghanistan, **banned** women from playing sports. So the team had to escape and now lives in other countries, mostly Australia. But they still play cricket and they just met King Charles! The King welcomed them at **Clarence House** in London on a super hot day. He told them, "I'm so glad that you can pursue what you want to do." Player Ekil Latifi left Afghanistan in 2021 when she was 17. She hasn't seen her family in five years. She said the team represents all the women back home who aren't allowed to play. "It's all about the Afghan women back in our country," she said. The team can't play in the **Women's T20 World Cup** this summer, which is being held in England. That makes them sad, but meeting the King was a big moment. He even joked, "If you lose, you can blame me for interrupting your training." The players gave him a signed shirt and pinned a badge on his suit. Latifi asked the King to say a "**posh** word" for her. The King also asked if they faced **protests** as female cricketers in Afghanistan. The team hopes their story will inspire girls everywhere to never give up on their dreams.

Word Treasure

Taliban -- A group that rules Afghanistan with very strict rules, especially for women.

banned -- Made something not allowed, so people cannot do it.

Clarence House -- A royal building in London where King Charles often lives.

Women's T20 World Cup -- A big international cricket tournament for women's teams, played in the shortest form of the game.

protests -- When people publicly show they disagree with something, often by gathering or speaking out.

posh -- A British word meaning something is fancy or connected to the upper class.

Background you need

Afghanistan is a country in Asia. In 2021, a group called the Taliban took over and banned women from playing sports.

King Charles III became the King of the United Kingdom in 2022; he lives in Clarence House, a royal building in London.

The Women's T20 World Cup is a cricket tournament where teams from different countries compete; Afghanistan's women's team cannot play because their home country does not recognize them.

Break it down

WHO: The Afghan women's cricket team (now living in Australia) and King Charles III.

WHAT: The team, forced to leave Afghanistan because the Taliban banned women's sports, met the King in London to share their story.

WHERE: Clarence House, London, England.

WHY: To show that even without a country to play for, they represent Afghan women who cannot play, and to inspire girls worldwide to keep their dreams alive.

Why it matters

This story reminds us that even when rules seem unfair, people can find ways to keep doing what they love and speak up for others, no matter where they live.

Test what you remember

1. Who did the Afghan women's cricket team meet?
 - (A) A famous singer
 - (B) King Charles
 - (C) The President of the United States
 - (D) An Olympic athlete
2. Where did the meeting take place?
 - (A) At a cricket stadium
 - (B) In Afghanistan
 - (C) At Clarence House in London
 - (D) In Australia
3. Why can't the Afghan women's cricket team play for their home country?
 - (A) They don't have enough players
 - (B) The Taliban banned women from playing sports
 - (C) They lost their equipment
 - (D) Nobody in Afghanistan likes cricket
4. Which tournament can't they play in this summer?
 - (A) The Cricket World Cup
 - (B) The Women's T20 World Cup
 - (C) The Olympic Games
 - (D) The London Cricket Championship
5. What did player Ekil Latifi ask the King to say?
 - (A) A funny joke
 - (B) A cricket rule
 - (C) A posh word
 - (D) A secret code
6. What does the team hope their story will do?
 - (A) Make them rich
 - (B) Inspire girls everywhere to never give up
 - (C) Force the Taliban to play cricket
 - (D) Get them back into Afghanistan soon

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. The Players: They feel proud to represent the women of Afghanistan and hope their bravery will someday change the rules. Meeting the King made them feel seen and respected.

2. The Taliban: They believe women should not play sports or appear in public this way, which is why they banned the team. Many people around the world think this is deeply unfair.

3. King Charles and Supporters: By welcoming the team, the King and others show they stand with women's rights. They believe girls everywhere should be able to follow their passions without fear.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):